



How Will God Judge?

Sabbath School Study Notes

Lesson 5

PHASE 4 SDA BRANCH

Revelation 14:7

THE FIRST ANGEL'S MESSAGE • LESSON 5 • REVELATION 14:7

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Revelation 14:7

R Recap

We have discussed at length the partiality of justice systems in the world — and why we need an impartial system that will make all things fair. Our framework for understanding judgment is:

WHO	God
WHAT	Judgment — a decision-making, opinion-based legal system
WHERE	The heavenly sanctuary
WHY	To bring every deed into judgment and reveal whether it is good or bad
HOW	To be addressed in this lesson

1 The Standard of God's Judgment

Psalms 73:1–17 | Ecclesiastes 8:11

Asaph wrestled with a painful observation: the wicked seem to prosper while the faithful suffer. Ecclesiastes 8:11 adds to this tension — because judgment is not immediate, people grow bold in doing wrong.

This raises an important question: if sin were punished immediately, would the world consider God's judgment fair? Most likely, yes. But would that system truly be just by God's own standard?

SPIRIT OF
PROPHECY

"If we lived in a dispensation of immediate retribution, offenses against God would not occur so often." — 3BC 1166.1

1 John 3:4 | Proverbs 11:1 | Proverbs 16:11

Sin is defined as the transgression of God's law (1 John 3:4). Proverbs 11:1 and 16:11 tell us that honest weights and scales belong to the Lord — God's standard of measurement is perfect and impartial.

Consider how human legal systems attempt to tier punishment by the severity of a crime:

Sin	Human Punishment
Rape	Capital punishment

Abuse	10 years imprisonment
Theft (minor)	1 year imprisonment

But if the same punishment applied to lying as to rape, would that be fair? By human logic, no. Yet God's standard is not measured in terms of severity alone — it encompasses the full character of every act.

Ecclesiastes 12:14

God will bring every work into judgment — including every hidden thing, whether good or evil. This is the scope of His judgment.

SPIRIT OF PROPHECY

"Every action and every course of action has a two-fold character, be it virtuous or demoralizing." — LYL 42.3–42.4

2 The Two Dimensions of Every Act

Matthew 23:27–28 | Matthew 15:8 | 2 Timothy 3:5

God's judgment accounts not only for actions but for the thoughts, intentions, and motives behind them. Jesus described a group of people as whitewashed tombs — beautiful on the outside, but full of corruption within (Matthew 23:27–28). These are people who, as 2 Timothy 3:5 says, have a form of godliness but deny its power.

Matthew 15:8 captures this plainly: they draw near with their lips, but their heart is far from God. The outward act without an inward heart is meaningless to God.

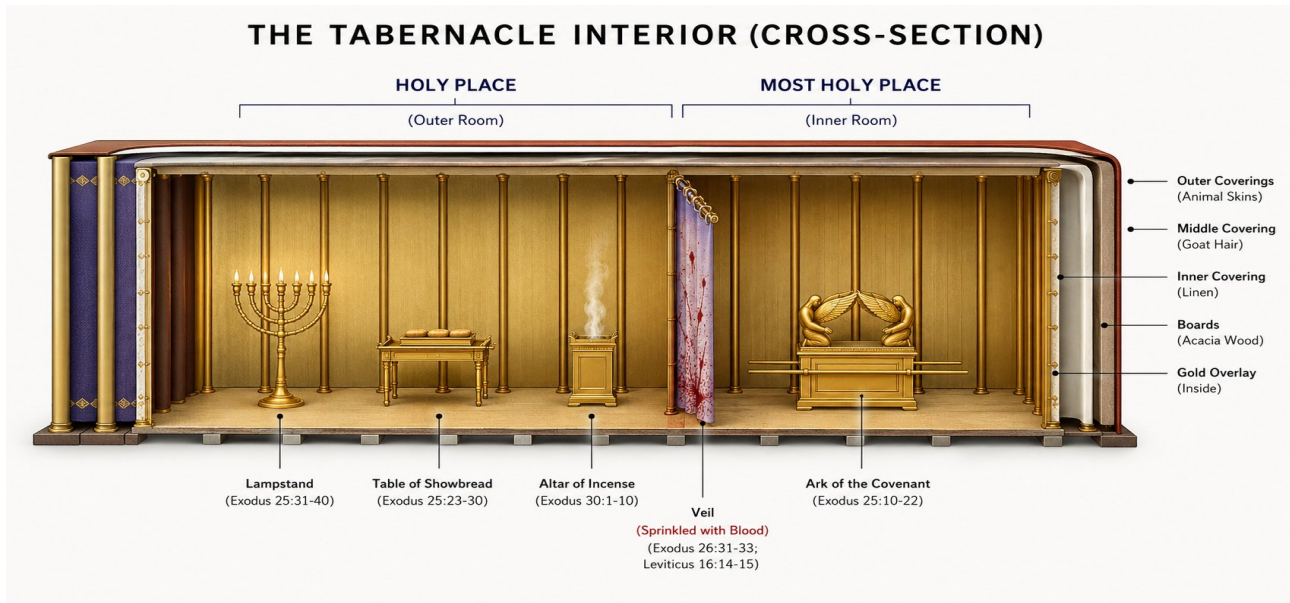
3 The Sanctuary and the Evidence of Sin

Leviticus 4:1–29

In the Old Testament sanctuary system, God established a visible, structured way of dealing with sin. Leviticus 4 identifies four categories of people who could sin — and each was required to bring a sacrifice:

Category	Reference
The Priest	Leviticus 4:1–7
The Congregation	Leviticus 4:11–17
The Ruler	Leviticus 4:22–25
The Common People	Leviticus 4:27–29

As part of this process, the sinner would confess their sin and lay their hand on the head of the sacrifice — symbolically transferring the sin to the animal, which took the sinner's place. Each time an animal was slain, some of its blood was sprinkled on the veil that separated the Holy Place from the Most Holy Place.



The Tabernacle Interior (Cross-Section) — showing the Holy Place, the veil sprinkled with blood (Exodus 26:31–33; Leviticus 16:14–15), and the Most Holy Place with the Ark of the Covenant.

The veil, originally white, would by the end of the year bear the visible, accumulated record of the sins of the people — a physical testimony of what had been confessed and transferred. This was the evidence.

Leviticus 16 | Daniel 7:9–10

Once a year, on the Day of Atonement (Leviticus 16), the sanctuary was cleansed — a solemn day of judgment in which the accumulated sins of the year were dealt with. This was the annual reset.

Daniel 7:9–10 carries us forward to the heavenly counterpart of this scene: the court is seated, and the books are opened. Everything chronicled in those books is brought into review.

4 The Three Books of Heaven

There are three books in heaven that bear the complete record of humanity:

Book 1 — The Book of Misdeeds

Matthew 12:36–37 | Romans 3:23

Every idle word, every sinful act, every unfulfilled duty is recorded here. Just as the veil in the sanctuary bore the blood-record of every sin confessed by Israel, the Book of Misdeeds bears a more profound and exact record — spanning from the sin of Adam and Eve to the last sin that will ever be committed.

**GREAT
CONTROV
ERSY**

"Opposite each name in the books of Heaven is entered, with terrible exactness, every wrong word, every selfish act, every unfulfilled duty, and every secret sin, with every artful dissembling. Heaven-sent warnings or reproofs neglected, wasted moments, unimproved opportunities, the influence exerted for good or for evil, with its far-reaching results, all are chronicled by the recording angel." — GC88 481.2–481.3

Book 2 — The Book of Remembrance

Malachi 3:16 | Psalm 56:8

This is good news. Notice the connection: Malachi 3:16 says this book was written for those who fear the Lord — and the first words of the First Angel's Message are "Fear God." The connection is deliberate.

Every act of faithfulness is immortalised here: every temptation resisted, every act of kindness, every word of tender care. Joseph resisting Potiphar's wife. Caleb and Joshua holding to the promise. The time you stood for God when it cost you something. All of it recorded.

**GREAT
CONTROV
ERSY**

"In the book of God's remembrance every deed of righteousness is immortalized. There every temptation resisted, every evil overcome, every word of tender pity expressed, is faithfully chronicled. And every act of sacrifice, every suffering and sorrow endured for Christ's sake, is recorded." — GC88 481.1

Book 3 — The Book of Life

Exodus 32:9–14, 31–33 | Revelation 21:27

In Exodus 32, we see Moses interceding before God on behalf of the children of Israel after they sinned with the golden calf. He stands not merely as a leader but as an advocate. God's response in verse 33 is clear: those who sin against Him will be blotted out of His book.

Revelation 21:27 tells us that nothing defiled will enter heaven — only those whose names are written in the Lamb's Book of Life. Sin defiles. Sin is an abomination to God.

KEY QUESTION

If the Book of Misdeeds contains the record of every sin — and we know from Romans 3:23 that all have sinned — how can any name remain in the Book of Life? The answer is Jesus Christ. But how does it become Jesus Christ? What role does He play? This will be our focus next week as we look at the Day of Atonement.

5 How Will God Judge? — A Summary

God's judgment is not arbitrary. It is thorough, impartial, and complete. Every action is weighed — not only the outward act, but the intent and motive behind it. The sanctuary system provides the blueprint: sin is confessed, transferred, and recorded. The heavenly books carry the full account. The Day of Atonement points to the final cleansing.

The three books together tell the whole story of every person: what they did wrong, what they did right, and whether their name remains in the Book of Life.

NEXT WEEK

Next week we look at the Day of Atonement in Leviticus 16 — because it holds the answer to the most important question: how does Jesus Christ make it possible for a sinner's name to remain in the Book of Life?